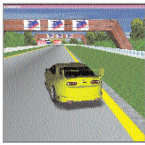


Driving Games Bad For Drivers

Driving-game players are bad drivers! Gamers and non-gamers were asked how safe they were and how often they played games. Gamers were more likely to display aggressive behaviour. The British School of Motoring is calling for a pop-up on driving games warning of the risk.



Gates For Prez!

A group of Microsoft fans wanted to get Bill Gates to run in the 2008 US presidential elections. They say Gates would make a "good president" because he's "rich, rational, unselfish and knows management." They even put up a site to convince Gates, but "Gates probably didn't feel the drive."



Escape

PIRACY IS GOOD

Thus Spake Raikes

This kind of thing doesn't happen too often, so it's all the juicier when it does. Microsoft business group president Jeff Raikes has admitted that software piracy *does* end up benefiting the company—Microsoft in this case. The reason he stated was that it can lead to purchase of other software packages.

Of course, we knew it all along—as we had suggested in an earlier article titled *Is Piracy Good*. There, amongst other things, we put forth the argument that if you pirate Windows at home, you're likely to get used to it and recommend Windows be used at your office, instead of having to recompile kernels.

Here's the official thing: Raikes told delegates at the Morgan Stanley Technology Conference in San Francisco mid-March, "If they're going

to pirate somebody, we want it to be us, rather than somebody else." Which makes a lot of sense, come to think of it. Of course, who else would they pirate but Microsoft is a pointed question. Still, the idea is, no one can prevent a die-hard pirate from pirating—just as a barbed-wire fence won't deter a determined thief—and so, why not pirate "us"? Now, this argument holds water only when you *don't* go by the official statements like "The software industry lost 10 zillion bajillion dollars to piracy last year." That argument assumes that a pirated version means a lost sale, which is too simplistic for words. Think about it: you download an album off P2P, and the RIAA counts that as a \$20 loss. What loss? You wouldn't ever spend that \$20, period!

OK, let's not get into the whole P2P argument, which

we've dissected in an earlier issue. The point here is, Raikes' argument comes at a controversial time—a time when the Windows Genuine (Dis)Advantage programme is getting flak because a lot of genuine users have been misidentified as pirates.

So is Microsoft going to give up on fighting piracy and suing Russian teachers and sending them off to Siberia? No. It's going to be a "soft" kind of effort, as we can gather. Raikes says it's against Microsoft's interests to "push" pirates so hard that they end up using "alternative" products, meaning mostly open source. What these statements will do to Microsoft's stuffiness, we can't imagine.

An amazing confession, this—that piracy might actually be helping M\$. What do Ballmer and Gates and all the rest have to say to this letting-the-cat-out-of-the-bag? Mind you, Raikes is not a puny spokesman; he is, like we said, a business group president! Well, Gates had nothing to say to Romania's

Whatever Happened To...

The Amiga

You've likely not heard this name unless you've spent some time finding out the origins of the first operating systems. Just a year after the first Macintosh, the Amiga brought rich colours to the desktop, crisp 4-channel sound in tow, complete with pre-emptive multi-tasking, even. And yet, right from the beginning, it's been relatively ignored by the media.

Gaming enthusiasts, though, recognised its abilities and the Amiga became quite the gaming platform during the 80s. With future releases, it started to become a platform for serious video editing. And so, as the years went by, the Amiga enjoyed a niche, but secure place in the computer market—till Commodore, who owned the Amiga brand, ran itself into the ground. Gateway, the company that eventually took over, managed to release AmigaOne motherboards for the OS, but strangely, forgot that the OS wasn't ready yet! AmigaOne motherboards shipped with Linux instead.

Today, Amiga is the responsibility of Hyperion Entertainment, who announced the final release of Amiga OS4 earlier this year. Unfortunately, you can't try it out on your regular PC—it needs the AmigaOne platform to run. But the bigger question—will Amiga regain the cult following it once had? Chances are, no—it may still have a few nostalgic followers, but that's about it.

Win! My Desktop

No winners this month!

There were repeats of old ideas, but none that stood out the way the past few did. Try again!

Participate in this contest and win next month
Amazon.com MASHUPS
by Francis Shanahan

Published by
WILEY-INDIA



Send in your Desktop with a description of how you made it to mydesktop@thinkdigit.com with the subject "My Desktop", and tell us your postal address, too.